

What's in the Bottle?

Region · Grape · Style — A Global Cheat Sheet

Old World wines rarely show the grape on the label — you're expected to know that Sancerre means Sauvignon Blanc and Chablis means Chardonnay. This guide decodes every major region so you always know what's inside. kazmicellars.com

■■ France		
AOC — Place-Forward. The appellation tells you the grape. Grape rarely shown on label.		
REGION	GRAPE(S)	STYLE
Sancerre / Pouilly-Fumé <i>Loire Valley</i>	<i>Sauvignon Blanc</i>	Bright, mineral, citrus-driven, flinty WHITE
Chablis <i>Northern Burgundy</i>	<i>Chardonnay</i>	Crisp, flinty, unoaked, oyster-shell minerality WHITE
White Burgundy <i>Meursault, Puligny, Chassagne</i>	<i>Chardonnay</i>	Rich, layered, oaked, hazelnut and bread WHITE
Red Burgundy <i>Volnay, Pommard, Gevrey-Chambertin</i>	<i>Pinot Noir</i>	Earthy, silky, red fruit, forest floor with age RED
Beaujolais <i>Cru: Morgon, Moulin-à-Vent, Fleurie</i>	<i>Gamay</i>	Bright, juicy, low tannin, easy-drinking RED
Champagne <i>Epernay / Reims</i>	<i>Chardonnay + Pinot Noir + Pinot Meunier</i>	Sparkling — world's benchmark for fine bubbles SPARKLING
Left Bank Bordeaux <i>Pauillac, Margaux, Saint-Estèphe</i>	<i>Cabernet-led Blend</i>	Structured, age-worthy, cassis and cedar RED
Right Bank Bordeaux <i>Pomerol, Saint-Émilion</i>	<i>Merlot-led Blend</i>	Plush, approachable, plum and chocolate RED
Châteauneuf-du-Pape <i>Southern Rhône</i>	<i>Grenache + Syrah + Mourvèdre</i>	Spicy, full-bodied, warm Mediterranean herbs RED
Northern Rhône <i>Côte-Rôtie, Hermitage, Cornas</i>	<i>Syrah</i>	Smoky, peppery, dark fruit, sometimes bacon RED
Vouvray <i>Loire Valley</i>	<i>Chenin Blanc</i>	Honey, quince — can be dry or sweet, read carefully WHITE
Sauternes <i>Bordeaux</i>	<i>Sémillon + Sauvignon Blanc</i>	Sweet, honeyed, apricot, botrytis-affected SWEET
Muscadet <i>Loire, Atlantic coast</i>	<i>Melon de Bourgogne</i>	Lean, saline — the classic with raw oysters WHITE
Alsace <i>Northeast France</i>	<i>Riesling, Gewurztraminer, Pinot Gris</i>	Exception: Alsace labels show the grape variety WHITE

Italy

DOCG > DOC > IGT — Tradition-Forward. Region + tradition. Riserva = aged longer.

REGION	GRAPE(S)	STYLE
Chianti / Chianti Classico <i>Tuscany</i>	<i>Sangiovese</i>	Cherry, herbs, savory, food-friendly acidity RED
Brunello di Montalcino <i>Tuscany</i>	<i>100% Sangiovese</i>	Powerful, structured, age-worthy 20+ years RED
Barolo / Barbaresco <i>Piedmont</i>	<i>Nebbiolo</i>	Rose, tar, intense tannin — 'the king of wines' RED
Valpolicella <i>Veneto</i>	<i>Corvina + Rondinella + Molinara</i>	Light, cherry, easy-drinking RED
Amarone della Valpolicella <i>Veneto</i>	<i>Corvina blend (dried grapes)</i>	Rich, raisined, powerful — air-dried before fermenting RED
Soave <i>Veneto</i>	<i>Garganega</i>	Citrus, almond, light Veneto white WHITE
Prosecco <i>Veneto / Friuli</i>	<i>Glera</i>	Sparkling, fresh, peach and pear (Charmat method) SPARKLING
Etna Rosso <i>Sicily</i>	<i>Nerello Mascalese</i>	Volcanic, light, mineral — Sicily's Pinot Noir RED
Barolo (Langhe) <i>Piedmont</i>	<i>Barbera</i>	High acid, low tannin — Piedmont's everyday red RED
Gavi / Cortese <i>Piedmont</i>	<i>Cortese</i>	Crisp, almond, delicate — the white of Piedmont WHITE
Frascati <i>Lazio (Rome)</i>	<i>Malvasia + Trebbiano</i>	Light, dry, earthy — Rome's classic white WHITE

Spain

DOCa > DO — Aging-Forward. Aging tier is the headline: Crianza < Reserva < Gran Reserva.

REGION	GRAPE(S)	STYLE
Rioja <i>La Rioja / Navarra</i>	<i>Tempranillo</i>	Cherry, vanilla, leather (American oak signature) RED
Ribera del Duero <i>Castile</i>	<i>Tempranillo (Tinto Fino)</i>	Darker, more powerful than Rioja — plummy RED
Priorat <i>Catalonia</i>	<i>Garnacha + Cariñena</i>	Concentrated, mineral, slate-driven RED
Rías Baixas <i>Galicia</i>	<i>Albariño</i>	Saline, citrus, peach — the Spanish oyster wine WHITE

Sherry / Jerez <i>Andalusia</i>	<i>Palomino</i>	Saline, nutty, fortified — dry to sweet styles FORTIFIED
Cava <i>Catalonia</i>	<i>Macabeo + Xarel-lo + Parelлада</i>	Sparkling, traditional method, apple and bread SPARKLING
Rueda <i>Castile</i>	<i>Verdejo</i>	Crisp, herbal, nutty — Spain's best dry white WHITE
Bierzo <i>Castile / León</i>	<i>Mencía</i>	Floral, light, mineral — Spain's Pinot Noir equivalent RED

Germany & Austria

Pradikat System — Riesling-Forward. Sweetness level on the label: Kabinett → Spätlese → Auslese → BA → TBA.

REGION	GRAPE(S)	STYLE
Mosel <i>Germany</i>	<i>Riesling</i>	Floral, slate mineral, low alcohol — dry to sweet WHITE
Rheingau <i>Germany</i>	<i>Riesling</i>	Fuller than Mosel, peach and citrus, age-worthy WHITE
Rheinhessen <i>Germany</i>	<i>Riesling / Silvaner</i>	Broad range from simple to serious WHITE
Pfalz <i>Germany</i>	<i>Riesling / Pinot Noir</i>	Warmer, riper style — Germany's most versatile region WHITE
Wachau <i>Austria</i>	<i>Grüner Veltliner</i>	Peppery, citrus, herbal — Austria's signature white WHITE
Kamptal / Kremstal <i>Austria</i>	<i>Grüner Veltliner / Riesling</i>	Mineral, fresh, food-friendly WHITE
Burgenland <i>Austria</i>	<i>Blaufrankisch</i>	Spicy, peppery, dark cherry — Austria's great red RED

Portugal

DOC — Tradition-Forward. Native grapes dominate. Port is the world benchmark for sweet fortified wine.

REGION	GRAPE(S)	STYLE
Vinho Verde <i>Northwest Portugal</i>	<i>Alvarinho + Loureiro blend</i>	Light, slightly fizzy, fresh — perfect summer wine WHITE
Douro (table wine) <i>Douro Valley</i>	<i>Touriga Nacional + Field Blend</i>	Dark, complex, structured — the dry side of Port country RED
Port (Vintage) <i>Douro Valley</i>	<i>Touriga Nacional + Field Blend</i>	Sweet, fortified, dark fruit and spice — ages decades FORTIFIED
Port (Tawny) <i>Douro Valley</i>	<i>Touriga Nacional + Field Blend</i>	Nutty, caramel, dried fruit — aged oxidatively in barrel FORTIFIED

Alentejo <i>Southern Portugal</i>	<i>Aragonez (Tempranillo) + Alicante Bouschet</i>	Warm, ripe, earthy — Portugal's most food-friendly red RED
Madeira <i>Madeira Island</i>	<i>Sercial, Verdelho, Bual, Malmsey</i>	Unique oxidized fortified — can age 100+ years FORTIFIED

USA & New World

Grape-Forward. Label leads with the variety. AVA (USA) or GI (Australia) tells you where.

REGION	GRAPE(S)	STYLE
Napa Valley Cabernet <i>California, USA</i>	<i>Cabernet Sauvignon</i>	Rich, concentrated, cassis — California's flagship red RED
Sonoma Pinot Noir <i>Russian River Valley, USA</i>	<i>Pinot Noir</i>	Bright cherry, earthy, elegant — benchmark US Pinot RED
Willamette Valley <i>Oregon, USA</i>	<i>Pinot Noir</i>	Cool-climate, silky, Burgundy-inspired RED
Barossa Valley <i>South Australia</i>	<i>Shiraz</i>	Bold, jammy, chocolate, vanilla from American oak RED
Margaret River <i>Western Australia</i>	<i>Cabernet Sauvignon / Chardonnay</i>	Elegant, structured — Australia's most Bordeaux-like region RED
Marlborough <i>New Zealand</i>	<i>Sauvignon Blanc</i>	Intensely aromatic, passion fruit, cut grass WHITE
Central Otago <i>New Zealand</i>	<i>Pinot Noir</i>	Concentrated, silky, cherry — world's southernmost Pinot RED
Mendoza (Luján de Cuyo) <i>Argentina</i>	<i>Malbec</i>	Plum, violet, dark chocolate — Argentina's signature RED
Uco Valley <i>Argentina</i>	<i>Malbec (high altitude)</i>	More structured, mineral, higher acidity than lowland Malbec RED
Maipo Valley <i>Chile</i>	<i>Cabernet Sauvignon</i>	Firm, dark fruit, eucalyptus — Chile's Cabernet heartland RED
Casablanca / Leyda <i>Chile</i>	<i>Sauvignon Blanc / Pinot Noir</i>	Cool coastal, crisp, mineral — Chile's finest whites WHITE
Stellenbosch <i>South Africa</i>	<i>Cabernet Sauvignon / Chenin Blanc</i>	Structured reds, old-vine Chenin — Cape's finest RED

Other Regions Worth Knowing

Beyond the classics — regions producing world-class wine that most people haven't discovered yet.

REGION	GRAPE(S)	STYLE
Santorini <i>Greece</i>	<i>Assyrtiko</i>	Volcanic, saline, electric acidity — extraordinary white WHITE

Nemea <i>Greece</i>	<i>Agiorgitiko</i>	Dark cherry, herbs, smooth — Greece's most approachable red RED
Naoussa <i>Greece</i>	<i>Xinomavro</i>	Tannic, complex, dried tomato — Greece's Barolo RED
Bekaa Valley <i>Lebanon</i>	<i>Cabernet + Cinsault + Carignan</i>	Warm, spiced, complex — Château Musar is the benchmark RED
Tokaj <i>Hungary</i>	<i>Furmint</i>	Dry to intensely sweet — world's greatest dessert wine tradition SWEET
Etna <i>Sicily, Italy</i>	<i>Nerello Mascalese</i>	Light, volcanic mineral, elegant — the new Burgundy of Italy RED
Swartland <i>South Africa</i>	<i>Chenin Blanc / Syrah</i>	Old vine, natural wine movement — South Africa's most exciting region WHITE